

French A1 — Week 9 Student Overview

Crescere | Beginner French | Week 9

Theme: Plans and Obligations

What You Will Learn This Week

Week 9 is the week French becomes genuinely useful for everyday life. You will learn the most natural way to talk about future plans — what you're going to do, when, and with whom. You'll also add three essential verbs for expressing what you have to do (*devoir*), what you want to do (*vouloir*), and what you can do (*pouvoir*) — and learn to combine them in real conversations.

By the end of this week, you'll be able to discuss your plans, make arrangements, explain why you're busy, and suggest alternatives — the basics of any scheduling conversation in French.

What You Will Be Able to Say by the End of Week 9

Making a plan:

Ce soir, je vais aller au cinéma avec des amis. Demain matin, je dois travailler, mais l'après-midi je suis libre. La semaine prochaine, nous allons partir en vacances.

Planning a social arrangement:

— Tu es libre ce week-end? — Je veux venir, mais je dois travailler samedi. Dimanche, je peux! On se retrouve à quelle heure? — On se retrouve à 15h devant le café.

The Near Future: Aller + Infinitif

The simplest way to say what you're going to do is: **conjugated *aller* + infinitive of the main verb**.

You already know *aller* (*vais/vas/va/allons/allez/vont*). Just add the action:

French	English
<i>Je vais travailler demain.</i>	I'm going to work tomorrow.
<i>Tu vas appeler ce soir?</i>	Are you going to call tonight?
<i>Il va prendre le train.</i>	He's going to take the train.
<i>Nous allons dîner ensemble.</i>	We're going to have dinner together.
<i>Je ne vais pas sortir ce soir.</i>	I'm not going to go out tonight.

This is the future tense most French speakers use in conversation. The grammatical future tense (*je travaillerai*) exists but is more formal and comes later. For now, *aller + infinitif* covers everything you need.

Future Time Expressions

French	English
demain	tomorrow
ce soir	this evening
ce week-end	this weekend
la semaine prochaine	next week
le mois prochain	next month
l'année prochaine	next year
dans deux jours	in two days
bientôt	soon

The Three Modal Verbs

These three verbs are the building blocks of obligation, desire, and ability:

Verb	Meaning	Example
devoir (new this week)	to have to / must	<i>Je dois travailler demain.</i>
vouloir (from Week 6)	to want to	<i>Je veux aller au cinéma.</i>
pouvoir (from Week 6)	to be able to / can	<i>Je peux venir à 18h.</i>

Devoir — conjugation:

je	tu	il/elle	nous	vous	ils/elles
dois	dois	doit	devons	devez	doivent

No preposition between the modal and the infinitive: *je dois travailler*, not *je dois de travailler*.

Combining the Three Modals

This is where planning conversations come alive:

Situation	Example
You want to but have to do something else	<i>Je veux venir, mais je dois travailler.</i>
You want to but can't	<i>Je veux venir, mais je ne peux pas.</i>
You can if they want	<i>Je peux venir si tu veux.</i>
You have to cancel	<i>Je vais devoir annuler — je suis désolé(e).</i>

Key Planning Phrases

French	English
<i>Qu'est-ce que tu vas faire ce week-end?</i>	What are you going to do this weekend?
<i>Tu es libre demain?</i>	Are you free tomorrow?
<i>On se retrouve quand / où?</i>	When / where shall we meet?
<i>À quelle heure?</i>	At what time?
<i>Je suis désolé(e), je ne peux pas.</i>	I'm sorry, I can't.
<i>Ça marche!</i>	Sounds good! / That works!
<i>C'est parfait!</i>	Perfect!

What to Practice Between Sessions

After Session 17 — before Session 18:

1. Say 3 plans for the coming week using *je vais + infinitif*. Third try without notes.
2. Practice the time expressions until they come automatically: *demain, ce soir, ce week-end, la semaine prochaine*.
3. Try: say what you ARE going to do and what you are NOT going to do (*je ne vais pas...*).

After Session 18 — before Session 19:

1. Write a short message to a (real or imaginary) French friend proposing a plan. Include: *Je vais...*, *Tu peux...?*, *Je dois...*, *Je ne peux pas... mais...*
2. Say the planning role play out loud from memory: suggest → hear no → negotiate → agree.
3. Learn *je dois + your most common obligation* until it's automatic. *Je dois travailler. Je dois étudier. Je dois rentrer chez moi.*

A Note on Mistakes This Week

The most common error this week is **leaving out the infinitive** — saying *je vais au cinéma demain* (I'm going to the cinema tomorrow) when you mean *je vais regarder un film demain* (I'm going to watch a film tomorrow). Both are fine — it just depends whether you mean going somewhere or doing something.

The second common mistake is **adding a preposition** after a modal: "*je dois de travailler*" — wrong. *Je dois travailler*. In French, modal verbs (*devoir, vouloir, pouvoir*) are directly followed by the infinitive, with no *de* or *à* in between.

The Writing Task for Sessions 17–18

The curriculum writing task for this week: *Write a short note to a French contact about upcoming plans.* (4–6 sentences.) You'll use *aller + infinitif*, *devoir*, and ideally one of *vouloir* or *pouvoir*. Your homework will guide you through this.